

(4) Anglicanism (Anglican/Episcopal Church)

BRIEF INTRODUCTION

Anglicanism is one of the major branches of Christianity with approximately 70-85 million adherents (often called Anglicans or Episcopalians) worldwide out of approximately 2 billion (2015 estimates) Christians. Anglicanism (derived from Latin word Anglia for England) is the Christian branch that follow the common forms of doctrine, structure, and worship that developed over the course of the English Reformation (associated with Protestant Reformation) by the established Church of England.

~~The Church of England (Anglican Church) began its journey as a separate branch of Christianity in 1534, when King Henry VIII of England split from the Roman Catholic church because the pope would not grant an annulment to his marriage with Catherine of Aragon. Even though considered a result of 16th century Protestant Reformation, this split from Roman Catholic church was more personal and political than theological. But soon under King Edward VI (ruled 1547-1553) and Elizabeth I (ruled 1558-1603), the Church of England underwent many changes and reversals, and eventually acquired a distinct, an Anglican identity. An identity which is neither truly Roman Catholic (as its parent church) nor truly Reformed (as the Protestant) ; instead is thought of as a via media or middle way (or a blend) between Protestantism and Catholicism.

~~The Anglican Church considers itself to be part of 'the One, Holy, Catholic and Apostolic Church'. It (like the Roman Catholics) considers its bishops to be the successors of Christ's Apostles through an unbroken chain. But there is no central authority in Anglicanism like the Church of Rome headed by a single pope with supreme power. Rather each national or regional church (churches within the Anglican Communion) has full autonomy and headed by a primate (archbishop) but recognize the primacy (or first) among equals of the Archbishop of Canterbury.

~~Anglicanism spread to America, Canada, Australia, South Africa and New Zealand in the seventeenth century through colonization. And in the eighteenth Century it spread to Asia, Africa and Latin America through the work of the missionaries. In some countries (like America and Scotland) Anglican Church is known as Episcopal Church. Today most Anglican/Episcopal Churches around the world are part of the international body called Anglican Communion. Anglicanism (Church of England) is the official state religion of England. Large number of Anglicans are also found in Nigeria (18 million), Uganda (8 million), Sudan (5 million), Australia (4 million), Kenya (5 million), India (4million), America (3 million), South Africa (2 million) and Tanzania (2 million) to name a few (all population are estimates from various reports taken between 2008-2015).

~~Anglicanism shares many common beliefs and practices with Roman Catholicism being part of the One Universal (Catholic) Church until the split and also with Protestantism (of Reformed tradition). There is a fair amount of diversity in doctrine and practice among Anglican Churches due to the freedom allowed by the Anglicanism in the areas of Scripture, tradition and reason. Which gave rise to broad traditions within Anglicanism, such as the Evangelical or 'low-church' Anglicans (leaning more towards Protestantism) and Anglo Catholic or 'High-Church' Anglicans (leaning more towards Catholicism). But most Anglicans fall somewhere between the two.

~~In our following discussion we will focus only on generally accepted unique aspects of Anglicanism and where there are differences with Roman Catholic Church. So it is important to read upon 'Branches of Christianity' , 'Catholic (Roman) Church' and 'Protestantism' in our website before proceeding any further.

SOURCES OF RELIGIOUS/SACRED INFORMATION

Unlike Roman Catholics, Anglicans (like the Protestants) only considers the holy Bible as the source of religious/sacred information.

The Holy Bible: The Holy Bible of Anglicans is composed of a total of 66 Canonical books (like Protestants) but also contain 7 non-canonical books (like the Catholics who view these as Canonical). Anglicans consider these non-canonical books as part of the Bible, which could be used in worship as providing examples of life and instructions in manners, but not for the establishment of doctrine.

The Book of Common Prayer: Anglicans also accept 'The Book of Common Prayer' a foundational prayer book as source of religious information as it relates teachings from Bible. It contains the common liturgies for all the various rites and practices of the church, including the Morning and Evening Offices, the Eucharist, Ministration to the Sick, Reconciliation of a Penitent, and Funeral services etc.

KEY FEATURES OF BELIEF (Only the unique features of Anglicanism are discussed in this section)

Anglican belief and practice are drawn from the Bible, the traditions (with Biblical foundation) of the Church, Biblically sound human reasoning, the Book of Common Prayer and the 'Thirty-Nine Articles of Religion' (Anglican doctrine).

THE CHURCH

Anglican churches use Episcopal polity (like Roman Catholic Church) but unlike Roman Catholic Church there is no single central organization headed by a single pope with supreme power. Instead each national or regional church (38 churches/provinces of the Anglican Communion) has full autonomy and headed by a primate (archbishop) but recognize the primacy (or first) among equals of the Archbishop of Canterbury.

~~Anglican churches are led by bishops and its practices are decided by the General Synod. The General Synod is elected from the clergy and laity of each diocese and meets in certain intervals.

~~Anglican churches tend to reflect the appearance, atmosphere and liturgical structure of Roman Catholic Church. For example, most Anglican churches have altars, images and their clergy wear vestments similar to those worn by Roman Catholic clergy.

THE CLERGY

Anglican churches (like Roman Catholic) maintain threefold ministry of bishops, priests and deacons.

~~There is no bishop with supreme power like the Pope of Roman Catholic Church, all bishops are equal, sacramentally none is higher or greater than the other; none rules over other. They do carry different administrative title like primate or archbishop or bishop depending on the size, location and importance of their diocese. Like in Roman Catholicism, bishops are considered the successors of the Apostles.

~~Unlike Roman Catholic Church no requirement is made for clerical celibacy.

~~Almost all Anglican provinces ordain women as deacons, some ordain women as priests and a few provinces ordain women as bishops.

~~Some Anglican Churches ordain celibate homosexuals as clergy. While only very few allow ordination of practicing homosexuals as clergy.

MONKS AND NUNS

No major difference with Roman Catholicism except that certain Anglican orders are open to married people.

MARY

Anglican position on Mary is similar to Roman Catholicism except 'Immaculate Conception' and the 'Assumption of Mary'. Most Anglicans do not believe in 'Immaculate Conception', 'Assumption' and the intercessory power of Mary.

THE SAINTS

Anglicans respect, honor and observe certain 'saints day' but do not worship or ask for their intercession.

THE ANGELS

Main difference with Roman Catholicism is that Anglicanism rejects the intercession of angels.

THE SACRAMENTS (OR ORDINANCES)

Anglicans accept Baptism and Eucharist as 'great sacraments' or 'the Sacraments of the Gospel'. They recognize these two as superior in dignity to the others, as being clearly ordained by Christ

Himself during His earthly ministry, and as being, according to His own teaching, generally necessary for salvation. Anglicans also recognize the other five sacraments (called as 'sacramental rites') that evolved (not instituted by Jesus during his ministry on earth) in the Church under the guidance of the Holy Spirit.

Baptism: Anglicans baptize both infants and adults. They believe Baptism is a once-in-a-lifetime event, thus people with valid baptisms (all baptisms performed in the name of the triune God) from other denominations may not be baptized again upon conversion.

Eucharist (Holy Communion): Anglicans teach, in the Eucharist, the Body and Blood of Christ are given, taken and received by the faithful, and that through this Sacrament they dwell in Christ and Christ in them. They discourage scholastic definitions as to the mode and manner of Christ's presence (in the bread and wine), but they acknowledge it to be true and genuine as mysterious, ineffable and spiritual manner.

WORSHIP AND PRAYER

Anglican liturgy and prayer are in many ways similar to that of Roman Catholic Church. The format and details are laid out in the 'Book of Common Prayer'. Anglican churches display great variety in their worship, from very informal to highly liturgical, dependent on local, ethnic, historical or theological conditions.

~~Anglicanism also encourages individual daily prayer and Bible study. Anglicans do not participate in any kind of intercessory prayer (like Roman Catholic 'Prayer of intercession').

SIN

Unlike Roman Catholicism, Anglicanism does not categorize sins into mortal and venial sins. And also when one commits sin, he or she may confess to God through Jesus and ask for forgiveness which will restore the perfect fellowship and communion with God. One may also go to a priest (confess privately to the priest) if he/she chooses to but are not required to do so.

SALVATION

A major difference with Roman Catholics is that Anglicans (like the protestants) believe Salvation is through faith alone in Jesus. Salvation is by grace (free unmerited-undeserved gift from God) through faith in Jesus Christ. By faith Anglicans understand not a dead but a living faith, which naturally leads the believers to do good works for God (i.e. leading a life that reflects the teachings of Jesus Christ). To them there is neither contrast nor any permanent distinction between faith and good works.

~~Unlike Roman Catholics, Anglicans do not believe salvation can be lost due to sin (except for blasphemy against Holy Spirit).

ESCHATOLOGY

The main difference here is that unlike Roman Catholicism, Anglicanism (like Protestants) does not accept the concept of Purgatory. There is no cleansing with fire (like Roman Catholicism) after death in the intermediate period, one is either saved or damned for eternity.

INDULGENCE

Unlike Roman Catholicism, Anglicanism (like Protestants) rejects the concept of 'indulgence'.

STATUES AND ICONS (IMAGES)

Anglican position is similar to the position of Roman Catholic.

SEXUAL MORALITY

There is no major difference between Anglicanism and Roman Catholicism regarding the teachings about sexual morality. The only difference is that Anglicans (like Protestants) do not consider sexual immorality such as masturbation, fornication, pornography, prostitution, rape, adultery etc. (though considered as sins) can cause loss of salvation.

CONTRACEPTION AND CONCEPTION

Unlike Roman Catholicism, contraception is allowed in Anglicanism. Anglicans do not consider contraception (natural or artificial) as a sin or going against God's purpose.

ABORTION

Like Roman Catholicism, Anglicanism generally considers it to be immoral to have or to associate with abortion. There is no universal position among all Anglicans on Abortion. But unlike Roman Catholic Church, most Anglican churches allow abortion if there is a risk to the life or health (physical or mental) of the mother, or if there is a substantial risk of a child being born with physical or mental abnormalities.

DIVORCE AND REMARRIAGE

Anglicanism teaches that marriage is for life. But unlike Roman Catholic Church, most Anglican Churches allow divorce when marriages fail. They also allow remarriage under certain circumstances.

FOR MORE INFORMATION (Some Sources Used For This Article)

<https://www.churchofengland.org/our-faith/being-an-anglican.aspx>,
<http://www.episcopalchurch.org/page/anglican-communion>,
<http://www.anglicansonline.org/>,
<http://www.anglican.org/index.html>,
<http://www.patheos.com/Library/Anglican>,
<http://www.newworldencyclopedia.org/entry/Anglicanism>,
http://www.bbc.co.uk/religion/religions/christianity/cofe/cofe_1.shtml